



BEST WISHES: Sivaraman (left) hands over a health card to a teacher

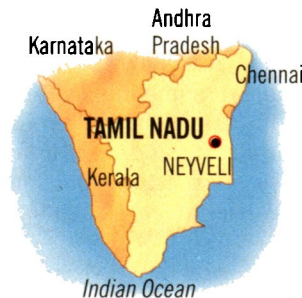
To Sir, With Love

An old students' association tunes its online network to help ailing teachers and their families

■ **By Mahalingam Ponnusamy**

When old schoolmates meet at an alumni meeting, they end up comparing their worth. But when the batch of 1977 of the Jawahar Higher Secondary School (JHSS), managed by the Neyveli Lignite Corporation, Tamil Nadu, formed a Yahoo group called Jawahar World Wide (JWW), to meet and chat online, something different happened—they ended up forming a philanthropic group. "One day while chatting, someone mentioned that the wife of our sports teacher Manickam was admitted to a hospital and we felt we could help," says S. Sivaraman, director in a pharmaceutical company and the coordinator of JWW, whose members are now spread worldwide, including the UK, USA, Australia and Canada.

Donations poured in and the teacher's wife recovered. "I never thought my boys will remember me 30 years later. Their contribution really helped my wife's pelvic cyst operation," says a grateful Manickam. This spurred the Jawaharites and they formed the JWW Trust to insure and help aging teachers. The Neyveli school, which has 15,000 students, employs a 500-strong staff, of whom nearly 10



retire every year. Those who are not covered by the corporation's group insurance get mediclaim benefits, with elderly teachers first in line. Some retired teachers looking after their ailing family members also receive Rs 1,000 every month. The alumni network has donated health insurance policies worth Rs 50,000 each to 175 teachers while the United India Insurance company has provided health cards.

The former students are now looking at ways to improve facilities in their former school. The trust has started equipping the school's labs and libraries with high-tech instruments as well as medical and science books. Economically weaker students are entitled to free special coaching. The trust is also setting up a system in which students who finish their studies get career guidance and even employment facilities.

"When I joined Jawahar, I was not good at science but the way my teachers taught the subject made me take an active interest in science," says A.N. Ravikumar, a nuclear researcher with a leading company in Canada. The teachers of JHSS did a good job and their students are paying them back. A perfect thanksgiving story indeed. ■